The Care Needs Cheat Sheet: Words You'll Hear and What to Write Down

Seventeen terms in one plain line each, and what to note when you hear them.

The care team has a vocabulary, and nobody hands you the glossary. These are the words you're most likely to hear this week, each defined from a public source, with what to write down when it comes up.

The definitions are for following the conversation. They aren't for sizing Mom up yourself.

Daily life

Activities of daily living (ADLs)

The basic personal tasks: bathing, dressing, using the toilet, moving to and from a bed or chair, caring for incontinence, and eating. [1]

WRITE DOWN Which ones she does alone, and which with help.

Instrumental activities of daily living (IADLs)

What it takes to live independently: preparing meals, taking medication, shopping, managing money, using the telephone, light housework, getting around the community. [2]

WRITE DOWN Who does each of these now.

Transferring

Moving into and out of a bed, chair or wheelchair. [2]

WRITE DOWN What she holds or uses, and whether someone helps.

Supervision or cueing

A helper gives verbal cues or a steadying touch while the person does the activity herself. Medicare's home health assessment calls this “supervision or touching assistance.” [3]

WRITE DOWN The tasks where someone reminds, prompts or stands by.

Personal care (custodial care)

Non-skilled help with bathing, dressing, eating, getting in and out of a bed or chair, moving around and using the bathroom. [2]

WRITE DOWN Who gives it now: family, friends or paid help.

People

Caregiver

A family member or friend who is helping. Medicare's discharge checklist counts the caregiver as a member of the planning team. [4]

WRITE DOWN Your own name, and what you do.

Discharge planner

The hospital's point person for planning what happens after the stay. It may be a dedicated planner, a social worker, a nurse or another member of staff. [5]

WRITE DOWN Their name and direct phone number.

Geriatric care manager

Usually a licensed nurse or social worker who works with older adults and their families to identify needs, make a care plan and find services. Also called an aging life care expert. [6]

WRITE DOWN Whether you've spoken with one, and what they'd want from you.

Physical therapy (PT)

Helps restore or improve physical movement after an injury, illness or surgery. [7]

WRITE DOWN Whether she has it, who comes, and the next date.

Occupational therapy (OT)

Therapy to help with activities of daily living, like dressing or bathing. [8]

WRITE DOWN Whether she has it, who comes, and the next date.

Speech-language pathology

Evaluation and treatment for speech and language, including cognitive and swallowing skills. [9]

WRITE DOWN Whether she has it, who comes, and the next date.

Paper, services and equipment

Discharge instructions

The written instructions for after the hospital. You should be able to read and understand them, and they come with a summary of her current health. [4]

WRITE DOWN Where your copy is, and its date.

Drug list

Every prescription drug, over-the-counter drug, vitamin and herbal supplement she takes, with any changes made during the stay. [4]

WRITE DOWN Where the current list is, and who keeps it up to date.

Home health care

Health care services given at home for an illness or injury. A doctor or other provider orders it and a home health agency provides it. [10]

WRITE DOWN Which agency, who comes, and when.

Skilled care

Nursing care and therapies that usually require a licensed professional such as a nurse, doctor or therapist. [2]

WRITE DOWN Which skilled services she has, if any.

Durable medical equipment (DME)

Equipment used at home for a medical reason that can withstand repeated use, such as a walker or a wheelchair. [11]

WRITE DOWN What was recommended, and who is arranging it.

Care plan

A form that summarizes a person's health conditions, specific care needs and current treatments. [12]

WRITE DOWN Whether one exists, and who wrote it.

What this sheet doesn't do

It defines words. It doesn't tell you which of them apply to Mom or how much help she needs. That's for the people who assess her.

Ready for the next step?

You can follow the conversation now. The care interview uses the same areas, in plain language: it walks you through Mom's situation one area at a time and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Administration for Community Living, What is Long-Term Care?
2. Administration for Community Living, Long-Term Care Glossary
3. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services, OASIS-E1 home health assessment, all items (definitions of assistance levels)
4. Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services, Your Discharge Planning Checklist (CMS Product No. 11376)
5. Family Caregiver Alliance, Hospital Discharge Planning: A Guide for Families and Caregivers
6. National Institute on Aging, Services for Older Adults Living at Home
7. Medicare.gov, Physical therapy services
8. Medicare.gov, Occupational therapy services
9. Medicare.gov, Speech-language pathology services

10. Medicare.gov, Home health services
11. Medicare.gov, Durable medical equipment (DME) coverage
12. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Steps for Creating and Maintaining a Care Plan

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